

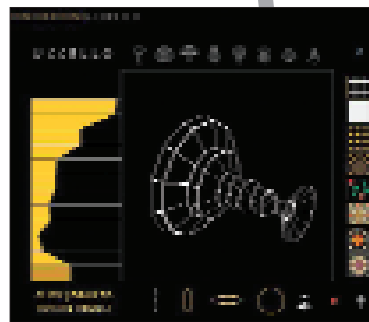


## Protozone

(http://www.protozone.net/AJinteractives.html)

Dazzling colours, 3D figures, symmetrical shapes—kids will love this place. Get them to draw patterns which they have seen in snowflakes, fabrics, inside kaleidoscopes and tiles. The 3D construction area is ideal for children with an interest in building. They can draw cubes, sculpt them, make patterns and while they are at it, rotate them. So detailed are the graphics that it looks like you're handling the real thing. There are two other sections—Games and Puzzles, and Art Machines. Each section has loads of stuff to keep one occupied for hours.

This Web site needs the Shockwave plugin, which you can download free from the Adobe Shockwave Website (http://www.adobe.com/shockwave/download/).



## ForgeFX

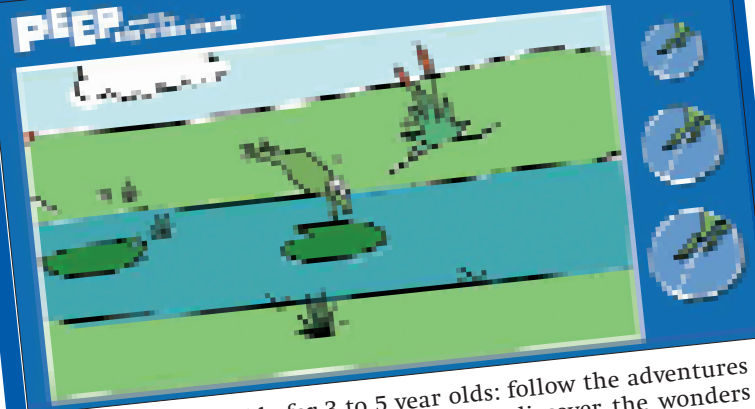
(http://www.forgefx.com/casestudies/prenticehall/)



Another site featuring the magic of Flash and Shockwave, this site—aimed at schoolchildren—attempts to teach them concepts like topographical maps, wave motion, eclipses, projectile motion, pheromone tracking and so on, through interactive and fun simulations. For instance, projectile motion and the concepts related to it are illustrated by the design process of a paintball-throwing catapult—the length of the arm, weight of the paintball, muzzle velocity and tension in the string all need to be adjusted to hit the bull's-eye. If your child is confused by topographical maps and how the contours of terrain are represented in them, increase the heights of hills and the depths of valleys and watch the ovals and circles change their shape in the adjoining map. This site has enough to satisfy the young 'un's curiosity, so you don't have to hunt down and read those science books yourself. The kids will ace their science tests, but will also develop scientific temper, which is more important.

## Peep And The Big Wide World

(http://www.peepandthebigwideworld.com/)

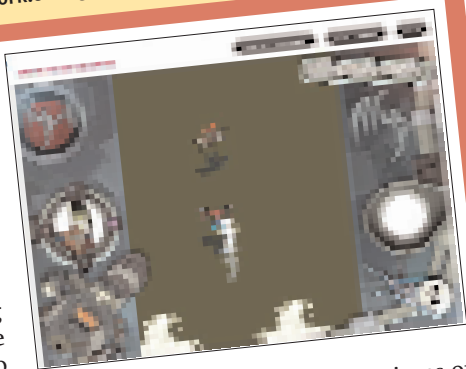


This site is suitable for 3 to 5 year olds: follow the adventures of three animated characters as they discover the wonders that lie in store for them. The cute chick named Peep and his pals—the little bird Chirp and the waddling duckling Quack, among others, have loads of fun.

The site is divided into several sections—activities, games and videos. The games and videos are all Flash-based, have voiceovers and load pretty fast. There's a new video every day: one day it could be about how Peep discovering that the, evil cat with giant legs and rows of razor sharp teeth was quite harmless, or it could be about how a seed grows up and becomes a plant. The games teach stuff through fun; for instance, the concept of primary colours is taught by splashing the wall with red, green and blue until the required colour appears. Nice, isn't it? Go ahead and check it out; we promise your kid will love you.

## Cartoon Network (Games)

(http://www.cartoonnetwork.com/games/all\_games/index.html)



How often we had wished in those afternoon cartoons of long ago that the cat gets whacked one more time, or the duck does just one more somersault before falling down. And those ads—how we used to bitch that it seemed we were watching commercials with bits and pieces of cartoons thrown in. Cartoon Network's Website solves all the problems. Here, choose from more than 170 free games, leap and whack to your heart's content for as long as you want and do it without pesky ads.

Most of the Flash games in this huge collection are engaging and attention-grabbers. There's no specific age group to recommend these games to, though the audience of these cartoons is an obvious target. That said, if you want a break from shooting at enemies or racing cars, you might want to exchange places with your little one and have a go at these games yourself. It would be a change, and a nice one.

## Thunk

(http://www.thunk.com/index.cgi)

Kids love mysteries. Experienced folks have always known that if you really want to hold the attention of children you involve them in activities which have an element of The Unknown in them. And what could be more exciting than secret messages and ciphers?

Thunk does not have the flashiness of other sites which cater to kids, but it does its job of introducing the world of encryption pretty well. The homepage has a section where plain English sentences can be scrambled into cipher text—next time you see something like “Zfz V jrec r trxn cfurl!” scrawled on your kitchen calendar, go to Thunk, type in the letters in the blue box and hit the unscramble button. “Mom I want a cake today” pops up; head over to the kitchen and get that oven out.

For kids, Thunk's scrambler and unscrambler open up a whole new world of fun. Imagine how cool and geeky it would be



if you exchange scrambled e-mails and jokes with your friend. In fact, if you send a joke that's really funny, it could be featured on the site (in scrambled version, of course). The site also has links to other interesting related sites like CIA for Kids and FBI for Kids. There is also a nifty section explaining all about cryptography and its history. Jn ran vzganbbnu, anrryl.

## In search of the Ways of Knowing Trail

(http://www.brookfieldzoo.org/pagegen/wok/index\_f4.html)

An incomplete letter from a father to a daughter about the secrets of the Ways of the Knowing Trail, a village in the heart of Africa—sounds like the plot for a jungle thriller. There are no murderers or detectives here—only the thrill of surviving in an alien environment using your knowledge of nature. Sound interesting? Well let's head over to Epulu to find out.

You start at an airstrip where there is a welcoming party—children whose parents live or work in and around the huge Ituri Forest that surrounds the village. After introductions, you hop on the jeep, which unfortunately breaks down in the middle of the forest miles away from your destination. You have to navigate through the forest relying on the experience of your friends.

What's interesting about this whole storyline is that the storyline becomes different depending on the choices you make.

For example, during the night you could either sleep in a burrow high in the trees or a jungle hut. Depending on your choice, you would learn stuff which you might have missed otherwise. Along the way, your companions introduce you to the sights and sounds of the forest... We won't spoil the fun by revealing the ending. Do it yourself, you know.



## Chevron Cars

(http://www.chevroncars.com/games/)

Remember “Cars”? Yes, the animated movie. What if we said we found a site where you could race cars that look like they came out from the movie?

As you might have already guessed, this site is pure fun and games. Car games are but one section of the games available here; there are other types of games available, including arcade and puzzle games. Reflexes, speed, manoeuvrability—you need your wits about you to beat the high scores in most of the games. Extremely addictive—so much so that we almost didn't finish this article as we played on and on and on and...



In addition to these games, there are loads of free stuff—stickers, wallpapers, post cards, colouring pages, and screen-savers that would keep the kids connected with the movie. ■

## Summing Up

Apart from the sites we have mentioned, there are thousands supposed child-friendly sites. We recommend using kid oriented search engines like Yahoo!igans (kids.yahoo.com) or Ask for Kids (www.askforkids.com) to search for them as they link to sites which are suitable for children. There is also the fact that most of these sites are usually slow to load, as they have plenty of graphics and animation—so you could get jerky videos if you have a very slow connection. One thing stood out like a sore thumb—the absence of engaging sites with local content. This is a pity, as India has a rich cultural heritage which can provide the raw content. Most Indian sites are filled with boring text which is sure to turn anyone off. We hope the situation changes for the better. Any takers?

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